THE HINDU
Sunday, October 11, 2026

magazine



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GLORY ABROAD, FEAR AT HOME

At the same time India's women athletes are rewriting records, girls are taking to the streets (yet again) to demand the right to be themselves





Athlete Vithya Ramraj with her three Asian Games medals; and (far right) student protesters in New Delhi. (R.V. MOORTHY, GETTY IMAGES)

Suprita Das

On the evening of October 2, two realities unfolded. As the Indian women's hockey team was making history in Nagoya, Japan, women across Indian cities were taking to the streets.

Hockey player Lalremsiami Hmarzote had put India ahead, and for the next 50-odd minutes, her teammates defended that single goal as though their lives depended on it, refusing to let China through. After 44 years, India's women won an Asian Games hockey gold.

Back home, women were walking. As part of a countrywide #WhyLoiter campaign, women took to the streets in pink, reclaiming public spaces and asserting something that should require no campaign, no slogan and certainly no courage – the basic human right to walk, linger and exist in public every day of their lives, without fear.

The next morning's newspapers brought in another Indian sporting triumph. Boxer Lovlina Borgohain had won gold at the Asian Games. And alongside photographs of her celebration was the story of an Indian hockey umpire who had been sent home from Japan following allegations of sexual misconduct, which he has denied.

For the past couple of weeks, this has been the strange, almost obscene rhythm of the news cycle. India's women athletes winning medal after medal in Japan, while reports of rape and sexual violence against women at home continued to pile up. The joy was real, as was the rage. In the national capital, women protesters broke the windshields of the buses they were dragged into for detention, for raising voices for their own safety. A quick-witted young woman even grabbed the ignition key of a bus in which protesters were being loaded and took off with it. "There is no playbook, no script to these protests," says Prachi, a young student who attended the Jantar Mantar protests last week. "It's so chaotic, and it's also funny at times. Nobody knows how to respond because it's so unconventional."

Who is the actual Bharat *ki beti*?

There is the India where its women athletes are breaking barriers, rewriting records and giving millions of girls reasons to dream. And there is the India that, year after year, cannot guarantee those same girls the basic right to move through the world without fear. It is tempting to call them two Indias. But is it really?

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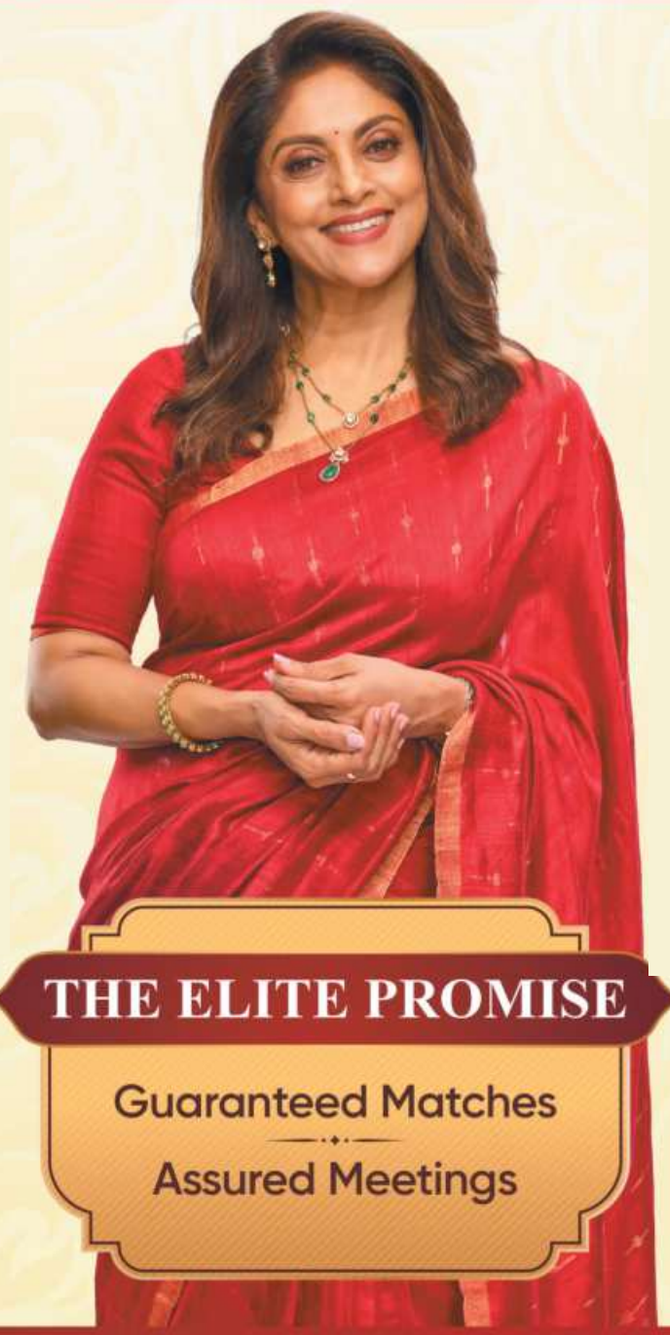
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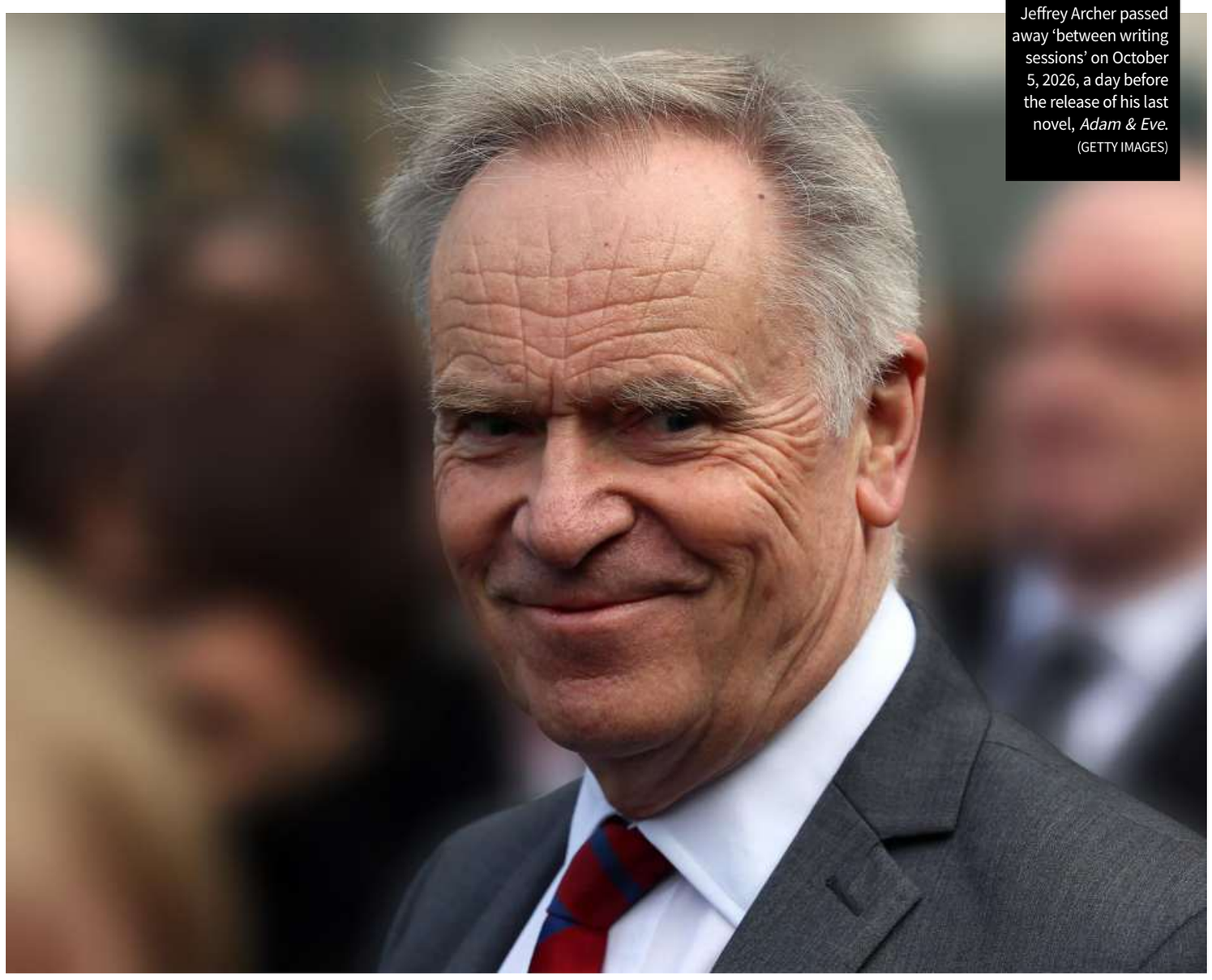
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Jeffrey Archer passed away 'between writing sessions' on October 5, 2026, a day before the release of his last novel, *Adam & Eve*. (GETTY IMAGES)

[1940-2026]

JEFFREY ARCHER SURVIVAL SPECIALIST

The author and politician faced head-on everything life threw at him, and was loved by hordes of readers, especially in India

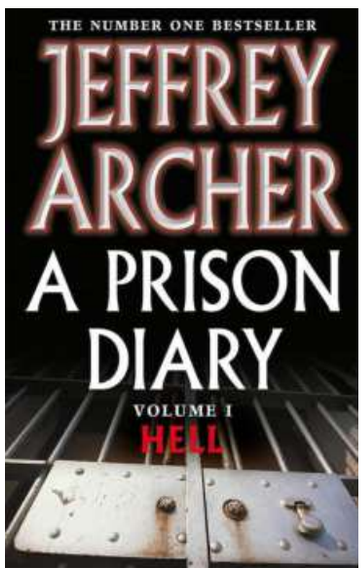
Suresh Menon

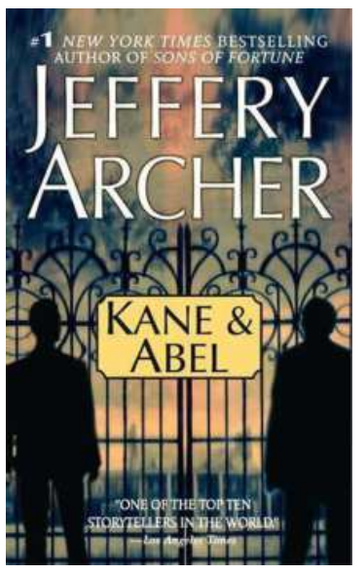
I found his novels unreadable, his short stories only passable, and his memoirs unconvincing, yet I had a sneaky admiration for Jeffrey Archer, who has died at 86. *The Man Who Got Away With It* might be the title for a biography of this Conservative politician, novelist, athlete, athletics coach, gymnast, police constable, PR professional, fund-raiser (and alleged embezzler of some of the funds raised), philanthropist, playwright, theatre-owner, fraudster with a side line in insider trading, jailbird, art gallerist, legendary party host, owner of Monets and Picassos, cricket lover and survival specialist.

Even in television interviews, Archer's unique combination of charisma and chutzpah came through. He had a very good opinion of himself, untrammelled by the inevitable pitfalls and comeuppances of "fifty lives rolled into one," as his (unofficial) biographer Michael Crick put it. He survived everything life threw at him, including cancer. He died "between writing sessions," said his publisher, and there is something to admire in that. He was loved by a reading public in India more interested in straight stories than literary subtleties.

There is a special place in our society for the gifted conman, for the tweaker of noses who is successful. This is what makes art forgers, and to a lesser extent, bank robbers such glamorous figures. Archer, wrote Crick, "was a nasty fraudster. He was a crook." He did give pleasure to millions, though. Death does not automatically confer sainthood, but it might in Archer's case. He might be capable of conning from beyond the grave.

The BBC's summing up was cruel if appropriate: (Archer) "died a wealthy man, albeit one whom very few trusted." Even when he didn't lie outright, Archer created impressions that were contrary to facts which he didn't bother to correct. When he returned to England after a spell in the U.S. (for a short course on physical education), it was assumed he had earned a degree there. On the basis of this, he got a job in a school and then one in Dover College which sponsored a one-year stint for a diploma in Oxford which helped him network his way out of ordinariness. You can fool some of the people some of the time.

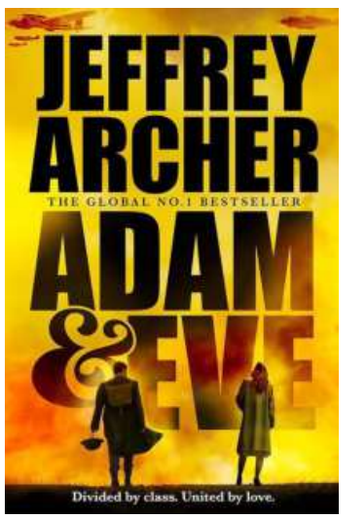




With success came scandal

For pop psychologists, the salient facts of Archer's life might be that his father (who was almost 40 years older than his mother) was a convicted fraudster who spent years conning people in New York. Archer himself was conned out of half a million pounds which led to bankruptcy and loss of his seat as a Member of Parliament. He sat down to write a novel (*Not A Penny More, Not a Penny Less*) to recover some of the money. That is as good a motivation as any.

He wrote novels about ambition, success, scandal, money, setbacks, self-publicity, rebuilding a life, all themes he had profound experience of.



With success came scandal – or maybe it was the other way around – and Archer spent two years (of four) in jail for perjury which led to a three-volume *Prison Diary*. He had once said, "When I was three, I wanted to be four. When I was four, I wanted to be prime minister." Only the first part of that ambition was realised, although he did rise to be Deputy Chairman of the Conservative Party under Margaret Thatcher and was later nominated to the House of Lords. He would have to be satisfied with being the nearly man.

By then, his charm, lifestyle and capacity for hard work had earned him the kind of success that is measured in the millions of pounds and a readership across 100-plus countries, including India, where he became hugely popular. He released some books first in India to counter those who pirated copies and denied the bookstores and publishers. He loved to repeat the story of being stopped in his taxi at a traffic signal and offered "the latest Jeffrey Archer" and telling the seller, "I am the latest Jeffrey Archer."

Of genius and talent

For all his success, however, he didn't convert the critics. "How could any sentient being willingly plough through Archer's dreadful prose?" asked the literary critic Robert McCrum nearly two decades ago. "To open one of his books," continued McCrum, "was to risk being assaulted by a hectic claque of cliché, mixed metaphor, implausibility, solecism and sheer, unadulterated stodginess sufficient to send most readers screaming in breathless delirium to the mature, lucid and urgent pages of Barbara Cartland or Enid Blyton."

Readers didn't care. Some 300 million copies of his books have sold worldwide. But the plots of his novels failed to match the twists and turns of his own life which he lived with an energy and conviction that could only have come from enormous self-belief which overlapped with disdain for those around him.

When Oscar Wilde was in jail, he quoted his friend and lover Lord Alfred Douglas as saying, "When you are not on your pedestal you are not interesting." Archer may have sensed this, but understood that being knocked off the pedestal at regular intervals served the same purpose.

Archer's prison books are unlikely to be mistaken for Wilde's *de Profundis* which was written in prison. But in one aspect, there is a connection. Like Wilde, Archer too put all his genius into his life and only his talent into his works.

The writer's latest book is Why Don't You Write Something I Might Read?

IN CONVERSATION

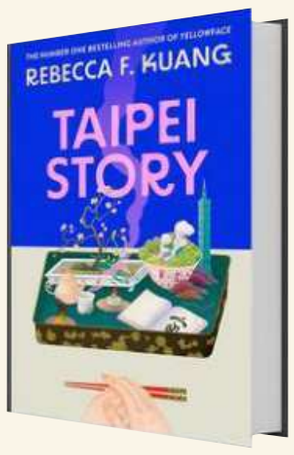
The fantasy of homecoming

Rebecca F. Kuang talks about subverting the tropes of home and belonging in her new novel, *Taipei Story*

Anushree Nande

Author Rebecca F. Kuang, who writes fantasy as R.F. Kuang, was born in Guangzhou, China, and raised in Dallas, Texas. She rose to prominence at just 21 with the publication of *The Poppy War* (2018), the first instalment in her acclaimed grimdark fantasy trilogy, which drew on Chinese history and mythology while exploring the violence and moral ambiguities of war. Since then, Kuang has moved fluidly between genres, writing historical and speculative fiction as well as contemporary novels that examine questions of race, identity, language and cultural power. Her latest, *Taipei Story* (HarperCollins India), is the bestselling, award-winning author's seventh novel and only her second contemporary work after *Yellowface* (2023).

In *Taipei Story*, Chinese-American college freshman Lily Chen spends a summer in Taiwan attending an intensive language programme. What begins as a formative experience abroad becomes something more urgent when Lily suddenly loses her grandfather on the mainland, forcing her to confront family, language and the complicated relationship between the identities she has inherited. Edited excerpts from an interview with Kuang:



Question: Taipei Story *is obviously a very personal novel for you. Did you ever think about writing it as autofiction or memoir?*
Answer: No, I always knew I wanted it to be fiction because I'm really interested in what genre templates can allow us to do. Once I had the themes I wanted to work through, like grief and confusion and struggling to reconnect with your heritage, I thought [they were] really good themes to explore through a coming-of-age novel. A story where the protagonist would be a lot younger and be experiencing [many] things for the first time. If I wrote it as a memoir, it's not that interesting because I was almost 30 when I lost my grandfather and I had figured out a lot more things by then. I had a much more comfortable relationship with my extended family and with Chinese. So, I think it was more fruitful to dramatise and explore these things from the perspective of somebody who would have struggled much more.

Q: *You make an interesting point in the book about the fantasy versus reality of the concepts of homecoming and belonging. Was this one of the themes that drove you?*
A: That's really what the book is trying to subvert, the fantasy of homecoming. A lot of people have this dream that if they can just learn the language, if they can just return, they can sort of pretend that those years never passed and that there's a version of them that never left and is close to their extended family and is perfectly comfortable in a foreign city. But many, when they do go back, are disappointed by their homecomings. They find that no matter how hard they work, they don't quite belong. And that's because they've chosen to make their life in a different place, and that's okay. *Taipei Story* follows in a long tradition of Asian film and Asian-American film that acknowledges that sometimes you leave for good and you have to make peace with that distance. I think Ang Lee films are especially touching in this regard, particularly his trilogy that includes *The Wedding Banquet* (1993) and *Pushing Hands* (1991).

Q: *Do you find that your multilingual experience has impacted the way you write or how you approach storytelling?*
A: Oh, for sure. Just as I feel all this freedom to reinvent myself in different languages, I also feel the freedom to reinvent myself in different genres. Having grown up on the outside, sort of, of various linguistic communities at first makes you pretty perceptive. You're always paying attention to speech codes and mannerisms and just vernaculars that other people take for granted and don't even think about when they're using them. Also, certainly for me, I don't feel like there's any voice that is my natural default voice. I'm always choosing a voice depending on the context; it doesn't mean that it's dishonest. It just means I code-switch a lot. And I also do this in literary genres. I pick whatever narrative voice is right for that story, but I don't feel locked into any kind of rhythm.

Q: *Every novel you've written has explored varied genres. Is this dictated by the story you are working on?*
A: I'm bad at planning ahead too far. I sort of just follow my gut. I notice what I'm gravitating towards, what I'm reading a lot of, and I always wait for that click between the set of questions I want to explore and the right genre format in which to tell it. Genre is such a flexible, useful thing. It's like a colour on a palette that you can use to sharpen or exaggerate different elements of something you want to crack open. Some of it is also just luck and spontaneity. I'm always open to telling a story in a way that I never have before. That's the fun of not planning ahead – I have no idea what I'll be working on two years from now, which is exciting.

The interviewer is a Mumbai-based author and editor.



Author Rebecca F. Kuang, who writes fantasy as R.F. Kuang. (TOBY MADDEN)

Pavement, a reader's paradise

Kanupriya Dhingra traces the history of Delhi's Daryaganj book market and its place in the city's unofficial intellectual life

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta

To learn to read is to light a fire," wrote Victor Hugo. "Every syllable is a spark."

Reading is fundamental. In every generation, children first learn to read and then read to learn. The history of the word has been one of widening access. Some 3,500 years before the Common Era, Mesopotamia developed the cuneiform script to maintain administrative records. Phoenician traders introduced an early alphabet based on sounds. The ancient Greeks wrote their texts as *scriptio continua*, a continuous stream without punctuation. Nevertheless, throughout this period and for centuries thereafter, reading remained the preserve of an elite few.

It was only in the 15th century, after Gutenberg invented the movable type printing press, that reading started to become affordable and accessible to everyone. Ordinary citizens could now engage with words and text directly. In the 18th century, the spread of coffee houses, followed by the advent of industrial printing, public education, and free public libraries further created a more informed and opinionated reading public.

An element of this narrative that is often ignored is the street bookseller. From the pavements of 17th century Paris and Victorian London to those of College Street in Kolkata and Flora Fountain in Mumbai, street booksellers have formed an integral part of this transformation: from elite luxury to mass reading habit.

An informal market

Kanupriya Dhingra's book is about one such street market, the Daryaganj Sunday Book Bazaar. Beginning with a personal childhood experience, her fascination with the market grew as a college student, when she lived in Satya Niketan in Delhi and became a regular purveyor of the books and atmosphere at the bazaar. As a researcher, her obsession became an academic interest. While conducting research on old writing manuals in Old Delhi, she discovered the spirited world of informal book markets. During her Ph.D at SOAS University of London, she began to research the Daryaganj Sunday Book Bazaar.

Over months, every Sunday morning, as cardboard and iron boxes full of books were brought in and arranged, she watched the transformation of empty footpaths into a pop-up book bazaar. Using ethnographic observation, oral histories, archival research, and close attention to the market's nuances and rhythms as it was brought to life and taken down every Sunday, she set out to understand how the book bazaar functioned within an informal economy as a site of human connection and community.

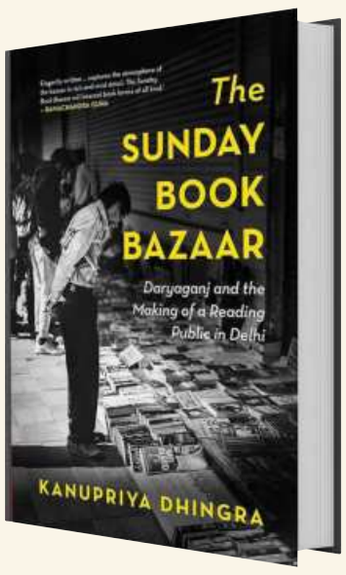
In Dhingra's account, the market is no ordinary phenomenon. She places it within the older historical book cultures of the city. Regular visitors include not only aficionados but the city's populations of students and migrants. Interacting with booksellers, buyers, and regular visitors, she follows its evolution from the 1960s as a motley collection of vinyl records, artefacts, and used books, through eviction and legal struggle into a unique cultural institution in this century. When the market was to be relocated to Mahila Haat, it was not only the booksellers who felt a sense of disorientation; habitual visitors, too, felt the change. "The sudden quietness of Sunday mornings felt almost uncanny. The streets that had once buzzed with argument, negotiation, and discovery now stood eerily vacant... '*Shayad khatam hi ho gaya*,' a young man suggested quietly, disappointment evident in his voice. 'I think it's over.'"

Titles old and new

Nevertheless, the market proved resilient, unfolding and rearranging itself into the new space. Dhingra describes the booksellers themselves as expert readers of their customers, knowing what each reader is looking for and displaying their books accordingly. This gives the book a larger argument.

An organised bookstore shelves and categorises its books in more structured ways; without romanticising it, a street market is a series of diverse and, hopefully, compelling encounters with old and new titles. Serendipitous discoveries can lead to new directions in reading. I am reminded of the Mumbai columnist Busybee who wrote movingly about the pavement bookstalls of Flora Fountain, comparing the books to autumn leaves scattered on the ground. The form of the book suits its subject. The street book market resists tidy categories. Its description calls for an interweaving of ethnography, urban history, memoir, and poetry. "*Faiz nahar jaari hai*," notes Dhingra: Faiz canal, the 14th century canal whose waters flowed through Chandni Chowk and Daryaganj, lives on – not as water, but as the flow of books and ideas circulating in this street marketplace every Sunday morning.

This is also a book about Delhi itself. The city is different things to different people. *The Sunday Book Bazaar* belongs to the city of the common reader. For historian Sohail Hashmi, notes Dhingra, the bazaar "is not separable from the city. It is one of the places where Delhi thinks about itself, where objects circulate, where the city's unofficial intellectual life has long been conducted, without any fanfare".



The Sunday Book Bazaar: Daryaganj and the Making of a Reading Public in Delhi
Kanupriya Dhingra
Speaking Tiger
₹599

The reviewer is in the IAS.


At the Daryaganj book market. (GETTY IMAGES)



India has roughly 4 lakh sq.km. of forests where tigers can potentially exist, but only one-fourth of this area has tigers in reasonable numbers. If we manage it properly, we can have 15,000-20,000 tigers within government forests

INTERVIEW

GIVING WILDLIFE MORE ROOM

Conservation scientist K. Ullas Karanth argues that India needs more protected habitat and less dependence on forest resources to conserve wildlife

Preeti Zachariah
preeti.zachariah@thehindu.co.in

The walls of K. Ullas Karanth's office in Bengaluru are lined with striking photographs of tigers, unsurprising for a man who has spent decades studying the striped phantom of the forest. One shows his younger self in camouflage gear, posing with a tranquillised tiger. It was taken in January 1990, when he had captured and collared the tigress labelled as T-02, nicknamed Sundari.

This picture, and the incident behind it, are both part of *Tiger Memories: My Life in Wildlife Conservation*, Karanth's latest book, co-authored with Bengaluru-based writer Joshua Mathew. It traces the tiger expert's lifelong passion for the natural world, his pioneering contributions to tiger research and conservation in India, and the successes, challenges, regrets, and disappointments he encountered along the way.

Karanth, a recipient of numerous honours, including the Padma Shri, is the founder of the Centre for Wildlife Studies, a conservation, research, and education organisation based in Bengaluru. In this interview, he explains why he emphasises less on co-existence and more on protecting habitats, enforcing laws, and reducing dependence on forest resources. Edited excerpts:

Question: *You push back on the emphasis on co-existence and community conservation, arguing instead that effective forest departments, land protection, strong laws and policies, and the voluntary relocation of people are more important. Could you elaborate?*

Answer: In the Brazilian Amazon, where human population densities are low, that sort of co-existence between humans and wildlife is possible as long as bio-resource consumption rates don't exceed nature's capacity to replenish itself. But this doesn't work in India, where local populations run into lakhs in and around tiny nature reserves. We can't change the availability of resources or human population density, but we can reduce biomass dependencies using modern technologies in energy generation and agriculture.

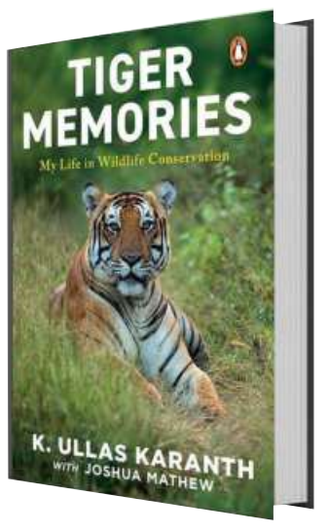
The number of animals that a piece of land can support is driven largely by three things: the animal's body size, its energetic requirements or diet, and its habitat needs. And we can't radically alter these determinants if the goal is to preserve wild nature.

When modern humans evolved around 3,00,000 years ago, we had no domesticated animals or farmed crops. So, our total biomass was only 3% of all mammalian biomass. After we started domesticating animals, mastering agriculture, and later venturing into modern industrial development, this changed. Today, humans and domestic animals together account for 95% of total mammalian biomass. Which means that in a densely populated country such as India, where dependence on biological resources is so high, our protection measures have to be pretty drastic if we really want to hang on to our wildlife. Protected areas in India cover just 4% of the country's land, which is nothing.

Q: *But doesn't context matter? In the Northeast, for instance, where so much of the land is under customary community ownership, isn't community conservation the best way to protect wildlife?*

A: Conservation definitely needs to vary depending on context. And we are fortunate that we have this tradition of tolerance in some parts of India. But this is a unique feature of Indian culture, unlike in most parts of the world, including even Buddhist countries of Southeast Asia. For instance, in Gujarat and Rajasthan, you will see herds of antelopes grazing in the fields. Of course, there are contrary examples – across vast forested areas of India, including the Northeast, such tolerance for wildlife is not the norm, but traditional mass hunting is.

But even if you accept all these big-picture arguments,



and even if 90% of people turn benign towards wildlife, a small fraction will still hunt or get involved in commercial wildlife trade and smuggling. In any society, you need some regulatory power over such crime; you need laws and somebody to enforce them. The question is: who should do that?

In the Northeast, the model that we have of the forest department and enforcement doesn't work. So, I agree we need multiple models. But ultimately somebody has to enforce the law wherever you go. And to say that you don't need enforcement at all, and people will not use wildlife and only tolerate it, is unrealistic.

Q: *Recently, a tigress from the Valmiki Tiger Reserve in Bihar was airlifted and released in West Bengal's Buxa Tiger Reserve, part of the National Tiger Conservation Authority's larger translocation programme. What are your thoughts on this, given that you have often said the country could support far more tigers than it does today?*

A: The moving of highly territorial cats between reserves is mostly unwarranted. If you look at all the translocation records, only some 5% are successful; most have failed, but nobody talks about these.

Right now, India has roughly 4 lakh sq.km. of forests where tigers can potentially exist, but only one-fourth of this area has tigers in reasonable numbers. If we manage it properly, we can have 15,000-20,000 tigers within government forests. Of course, it is a slow process. Tigers were almost extinct, but by bringing around 1 lakh sq.km. or so in different areas under some protection after the 1960s, their numbers have increased. Instead of reintroducing tigers, if you recover more potential tiger habitat through protection and build up prey densities, tigers will spread out automatically.

The case for physical translocation is extremely rare. Only if you have recovered the prey base in an area with no connectivity does it make sense to introduce some tigers, preferably pregnant females. If you simply dump tigers without ensuring there is enough prey, it causes conflict and leads to local hostility towards tigers.

Q: *Do you think the rise of wildlife tourism could play a significant role in conservation, especially given that the tiger is the primary marketing magnet in this sector?*

A: Wildlife tourism, in general, has not played a positive role in expanding our wildlife habitats. I think it has tremendous potential in India because it can boost the rural economy, which can help people who live around these protected areas. If a farmer next to a protected area can make more money from having wildlife on his land than from, say, growing *ragi*, she will automatically switch to more wildlife-friendly land uses.

We have seen this happen in Africa, where farmers get together, form a conservancy, and enter into an agreement with lodges that bring in tourists and a lot of money. But right now, in India, tourism companies aren't expanding the land base for wildlife; they are pressuring the same areas that are already protected.

We need to push protected areas to 10%-15% of our land, and that can only happen through economic incentives and development, not government diktats. If this money goes to people who own land next to the reserves, land use changes will expand wildlife habitats as well as reduce conflicts with humans.

GLORY ABROAD, FEAR AT HOME

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

"It's not a contrast," says senior sports journalist Sharda Ugra. "It's not two Indias. The women are negotiating and navigating the same India." That is the uncomfortable truth. Sport is a reflection of society in every way, and not some magical safe space.

Over the years, we've become very good at celebrating Indian women when they win. They are garlanded, felicitated, rewarded. They absolutely deserve every bit of it. At the recently concluded Asian Games, India's women delivered more gold medals than the men: 11, compared to the men's tally of 7, with 3 additional golds in the mixed events.

And this matters the most. It matters to the 12-year-old girl watching Kumkum Mohod, only five years older, topple Korea's archery domination of decades single-handedly. It matters just as much to the woman who, after watching Mirabai Chanu, all of 49 kg, lifting four times her bodyweight, finally walked into the gym. Because when women see other women take up space, take risks and win, possibility becomes visible.

Take a moment though to reflect on the 'Bharat *ki beti*' framing used each time a sportswoman excels. It sounds affectionate, empowering even. But the *beti* is also a deeply patriarchal framework: the good, obedient, respectful daughter who brings glory to the nation. "Outside this daughter framework that has existed forever, does she have no identity?" argues Ugra. "And when that same daughter demands accountability, or challenges the men in power, what happens then?" That is where the affection ends.

When the obedient daughter starts demanding to be heard, when she is angry, loud, abusive or unwilling to fall in line, the discomfort begins. In the wake of the CJP (Cockroach Janta Party) protests of July, Prime Minister Narendra Modi described young women using expletives and abusive language as a "cultural shock", adding that he chose to "forgive them". So, alongside the jubilation around the medal wins sits the question we need to ask: what kind of an India are these women really succeeding in?

When women challenge power

It's a framework we've seen before. The 2023 protests by India's most accomplished wrestlers – demanding the arrest and removal of Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, then-president of the Wrestling Federation of India, over allegations of sexual harassment and intimidation – showed what happens when women at the top of their game challenged power. The medals, fame and social standing did not insulate them from the machinery of the system. Athletes, including Olympic medallists Sakshi Malik and Bajrang Punia, and world medallist Vinesh Phogat, were forcibly detained. "The wrestlers' case showed me where exactly women athletes stand in the pecking order in India," Ugra says. "They have no status."

People were reminded of this when, in August, Modi addressed athletes via a video conference during the Khelo India Dialogue, and called for developing ecosystems in off-beat sports such as surfing and winter sports. Responding to him on social media platform X, wrestler Phogat wrote, "Prime Minister *ji*, how will [they] participate when the federations [in which they are participating] have goons,

Can the system be trusted?

In 2023, in the wake of the wrestlers' protests, the National Human Rights Commission issued a show cause notice to the Sports Ministry over the supposed absence of the law-mandated Internal Complaints Committees (ICC) in multiple sports federations, including wrestling. "There are more guards now. The committee members visit the facilities and hostels annually too," says 400m hurdler Ashwini Akkunji, former Asian Games gold medallist and now a coach. But the question is not simply whether a committee exists on paper. It is whether a scared teenager knows whom to go to. It is whether she trusts the system enough to go ahead and complain. It is about whether the person she is complaining about has influence over her selection, career and future. And whether there is anyone in that system who looks at the situation from her point of view. The answer is often no. "We need more female staff around, there's no doubt about it," Akkunji adds.



(Clockwise from right) Indian hockey player Jyoti Rumavat; archer Kumkum Mohod; weightlifter Mirabai Chanu; hockey player Lalremsiami Hmarzote; protesters being detained in New Delhi; wrestlers Vinesh Phogat and Sangeeta Phogat during a 2023 protest; boxer Lovlina Borgohain; and headlines from *The Hindu* and *Sportstar*. (SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA, PTI, GETTY IMAGES, AFP, AND REUTERS)

"There is no playbook, no script to these protests. Nobody knows how to respond because it's so unconventional

PRACHI
A student who attended the Jantar Mantar protests

"They [boys] operate from a space of entitlement. Like, it's my right to play here. What happens is a girl's body language and confidence change immediately

SHOBHITA NAITHANI
Parent of a 12-year-old girl

criminals, and people who exploit women...?"

Former India hockey captain Asunta Lakra's recent experience is an equally deeply disturbing one. In July, Lakra raised concerns with authorities after young women players in Jharkhand approached her with allegations of inappropriate behaviour by a coach. In an interview with ETV, she alleged that Hockey India's secretary general Bholanath Singh threatened her over the phone, saying, "*Aukaat mein raho* [know your place]." The allegation is now the subject of an independent inquiry.

Lakra's account is another version of the same story of what happens when a woman attempts to challenge power.

This came after Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya told Parliament in April that 33 sexual harassment complaints had been filed against Sports Authority of India personnel over the last decade: 8 against administrative staff, 25 against coaches.

The battle for space starts early

But perhaps the most telling measure of how safe women are in sport is not what happens to the champions on the podium. It is what happens to the girl who dreams of getting there one day. The battle for space begins much earlier. Sometimes, it begins in a neighbourhood field or a park, where a girl simply wants to play, and learns, often before she is old enough to understand why, that the space may not quite belong to her.

Shobhita Naithani's 12-year-old daughter looks up to India's women cricketers, and attends private coaching classes where things are structured. In their community playing area where they live though, it's a different story. The boys playing are more aggressive, and often disrupt proceedings when the girls go out to play. "They operate from a space of entitlement. Like, it's my right to play here," Naithani says. "What happens is that a girl's body language and confidence change immediately. They could be in the middle of playing football, and the boys start talking loudly to each other, warming up on the side, jumping around. It disrupts things mentally, and sometimes they just come back home with their tails between their legs."

Naithani acknowledges their privilege, which allows her to provide private coaching, drop-offs and pick-ups for her daughter. Most of the Asiad medallists, who her daughter has been reading about in the sports section of the papers, are not privileged. "I see girls who finish playing at 5.30 p.m. and then board a bus to get home," she says. "I would love to let my daughter do it, but I haven't been able to so far."

Instead, she's pointing at every private bus she spots and telling her child that's the kind of bus she should never board. Unfortunate as it is, the real life tragedies are the examples parents are using as references. The instructions that are muscle memory to women will begin soon enough, she is aware. "Stay on the phone with me," "ping us when you reach," "share your live location," "don't accept food and drinks from strangers."

The change has to begin at a micro level. Not with another safety manual for girls, but with lessons for boys on letting girls play. Because the burden of negotiating the world cannot forever be placed on the women navigating it.

India's sportswomen have time and again shown us what they are capable of. Give them a field, they will play. Give them a track, they will run. Give them a ring, they will fight. Give them an opportunity, they will give you medals. Perhaps, we've got the bargain backwards.

They shouldn't have to win gold to earn the right to be heard. They shouldn't have to represent their country to deserve a safe journey home. They shouldn't have to become 'Bharat *ki beti*' to be allowed to simply be themselves.

The writer is an independent sports media professional and author of the award-winning book Free Hit: The Story of Women's Cricket in India.





A demonstration in Hyderabad condemning the alleged sexual assault of a woman journalist in Delhi; and (below) a student protest in New Delhi. (SIDDHANT THAKUR AND ANI)

FIRST IN MY BLOODLINE

As protests unite unlikely allies, how women's rights become part of a wider struggle for a more equal India

Supriya Nair

So it arrives, feminist realism piercing this season of euphoric dissent. No matter how long and for what reason women take to the streets, patriarchy will refuse to give up even its evening stroll in the park. Men seeking to hold power to account say that we mustn't confuse issues by bringing the matter of women's safety to protests of national importance. We get it: violence against women isn't India's highest priority today.

But it is a fundamental faultline in every battle over every high priority. Men and women seeking India's social transformation must both know this and act accordingly. We see each other most clearly in moments of struggle. The young people bonding over mutual aid and memes in the student protests this July represent the possibility of powerful alliances across gender and sexuality. It is time to mobilise and speak up for each other's causes.

We mobilise because, first of all, there are real people, women, who are victims of morbidly familiar crimes, who must be feeling the greatest loneliness of their young lives right now, and who deserve to feel less alone. Second, it is because the rest of us are not victims. Indian women have experienced decades of upward socio-economic mobility, growing individual freedoms, and – most affectingly – improved access to each other. Almost all of us, as the meme goes, are the first in our bloodlines to live these vast, expansive lives.

It is time to put these gifts to use.

Bridging the gap

The most profound change that protest affects is within protesters, so it is vital for us to find our friends in these spaces, and to make new ones. This is generational work, and extends beyond the scope of seeking accountability for any single crime. Women live online now, and are vulnerable to the influence of our echo chambers in the way our grandmothers were to their caste and kinship networks. We are responsive to what hurts us viscerally, and socially sanctioned, publicly excused male violence is certainly a primary cause. But this isn't an isolated structural issue affecting women. It is linked to our economic security and livelihoods, which allow dignity and freedom to both men and women, and are fundamental to supporting more women in accessing public spaces and public life.

It is linked to climate, which represents both the most abstract and the most immediate crisis of our lives. Direct research linking heat stress to rising domestic violence is empiricising something that already feels true to many of us. We know that resource scarcity will dispossess women of opportunity at every level of society.

India's feminist history has historically anticipated and fought for justice in matters linked to these alarming changes, including housing and rising prices. It is time to bridge the gap between our anger at sexual violence and our strategies to confront the structures that enable it. No single solidarity march can protect women from becoming part of the growing underclass created by the climate crisis and global inequality.

Hard-won rights

Men also live online. Women must recognise that we are losing ground on the Internet, a key battlefield. The strangers in our parks may not have the privileges that the men reading this newspaper do. But neither are they taking to the streets to find friends and ringleaders. They are finding them in their messaging apps and on social media, in the comments section of the manosphere, which thrives on bullying the vulnerable. This in-groupism substitutes friendship and love with assimilation into shame culture, the biggest and dankest locker room in history.

That is a male problem, but it is an opportunity for feminists to think about our own unfinished work. Before the COVID-19 pandemic, the anarchic energy of the #MeToo movement tore through the hypocrisies of liberal upper-class life in creative industries, workplaces, and in India's proto-egalitarian dating culture. But the fragile pressure groups and support structures that began emerging for women have had no room to grow.

Feminists have institutional work to do in these spaces, especially in response to violent crimes like doxxing and deepfakes. As of this writing, men in the U.S., angered by the outcry over an alleged gang rape at Cornell University, are arguing in favour of revealing the complainant's identity – a cultural shift that, if it enters the mainstream, could roll back a hard-won judicial principle in ways that no rearguard action can undo.

The time is ripe

Men who like women and queer people but are removed from their problems must see this moment of dissent as a chance to join us in acting for a progressive, stable future – one not yet out of reach. Right-wing violence is increasingly inseparable from resentful machismo. It has tremendous force. It is time to accept what misogynists and traditionalists have long understood. Women's rights are a wedge issue, and giving them grace, and space, open up movements for everyone.

The odds seem stacked against us. But above all, and for the first time since the pandemic, the time is right. In India, this stormy monsoon of student protests has brought a coalition of unlikely forces into contact. Leftists and Ambedkarites, sceptics and pluralists, disenfranchised queer youth and religious elders are shaking hands across lines. It is a time to experience the struggles of others as our own.

The alliances between young men and women on the streets right now are imperfect, vulnerable to pressure. But we can protest in poetry and negotiate in prose. We owe ourselves that, and we owe it to the future to build relationships, both personal and institutional, that break with our past mistakes. It hurts not to be from the last generation to protest for our rights as sovereign individuals. It must have hurt those who went before us, too. But they were not afraid, and did not find themselves alone. Neither will we be.

The author is a Mumbai-based writer and editor.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty





GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

ALLEGEDLY

Coping with deletion

A voter, a notice and one very premature death

It was exactly six weeks ago that I received the following notice.

"It is proposed to delete your name from the electoral roll of [Name/Number] Assembly Constituency on the ground that you are reported to have ceased to be ordinarily resident at the address recorded in the electoral roll, on account of you being deceased. Also, you seem a patriotic Indian in the photo on your voter ID but resemble an anti-social element in your Aadhaar photo – a classical form of logical discrepancy. A dead man with a logical discrepancy has no place on the electoral roll.

Therefore, in exercise of the powers conferred on the Electoral Registration Officer under the Repression of the People Act, 1951, you are hereby asked to show cause why your name should not be deleted from the electoral roll.

Your reply should reach the undersigned by yesterday.

If you desire to be heard, you may appear before the undersigned, if you can, along with such evidence as you wish to produce in support of your case."

Electoral Registration Officer [Assembly Constituency]

As I read it, my blood pressure rose. My heart rate spiked. I told myself not to panic. I took a deep breath, and did what I always do in such situations. I went to see my spiritual guru, Sri Sri Paramaguru Triple Sri. I told him I was no longer a citizen of India, the only country till date to readily accept me as a citizen. "Now even India has rejected me," I said. "It is hurting my self-esteem."

The Guru has an answer

Guruji listened patiently. Then he said, "*Thambi*, it is not important what happens to you. But it is important how you respond to what happens to you."

"But *guruji*, why do logical discrepancies happen to good people?"

"Nothing is permanent," he said. "One day, sooner or later, each one of us will become a logical discrepancy in the scheme of the Supreme Lord and Creator. When you die, your name will anyway be deleted from the voter roll. Consider this deletion as an advance intimation of the inevitable. Instead of fighting it, accept it as a gift. You will find it liberating. Now go, and don't come back until you've done 45 minutes of Pradarshan Kriya meditation for 45 days.

I did exactly as he told me. Within days, I could sense fresh shoots of understanding sprouting in my anterior cingulate cortex. The least I can do is to share my newfound wisdom.

Joys of disenfranchisement

If you pause to think about it, you'll realise there are many good things about no longer being a citizen. Indeed, the happiest Indians are not the ones who are citizens of India. They are typically those that live as migrants, with no political rights, which mentally frees them up to focus their energies on work and family. They are liberated from distractions such as demanding accountability from the government of India, a burden that afflicts only voting citizens. In fact, our Supreme Leader's most passionate supporters – people who fill up massive stadiums in different parts of the world, women who weep tears of traumatic joy – are absent from our electoral rolls. But you never hear them complain.

All this protesting and marching to Jantar Mantar just because your name got deleted – isn't it a bit excessive? Asking for Gyanu's resignation – isn't that an overreaction? It's not like he had anything personal against any particular voter. He probably doesn't even know you exist (or used to). Then why make it personal by demanding his personal resignation?

Math of not voting

Incidentally, in our last general election, in 2024, the turnout was 66.10%. Out of 97.98 crore registered voters, only 64.64 crore voted. That means 33.33 crore Indians whose names were still on the rolls did not vote. If I was Gyanu, I would argue, "It's like their names weren't on the rolls at all. 33.33 crore registered voters, but no votes against their names. Compare that figure with the measly 13.3 crore names that I've deleted – it's nothing."

India had its highest ever polling percentage of 67.4% in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. It has never been higher. You know what that means? It means 29.73 crore names on the electoral roll did not show up at the polling booth. If you can persuade yourself that the ongoing SIR's 13.3 crore deletions are from this 29.73 crore electors whose votes would anyway not be counted, you'll feel much better. You won't feel like bad-mouthing Gyanu, harassing the Delhi Police, or, god forbid, do deeply '*dimagi naxal*' things like trying to protest at designated protest sites.

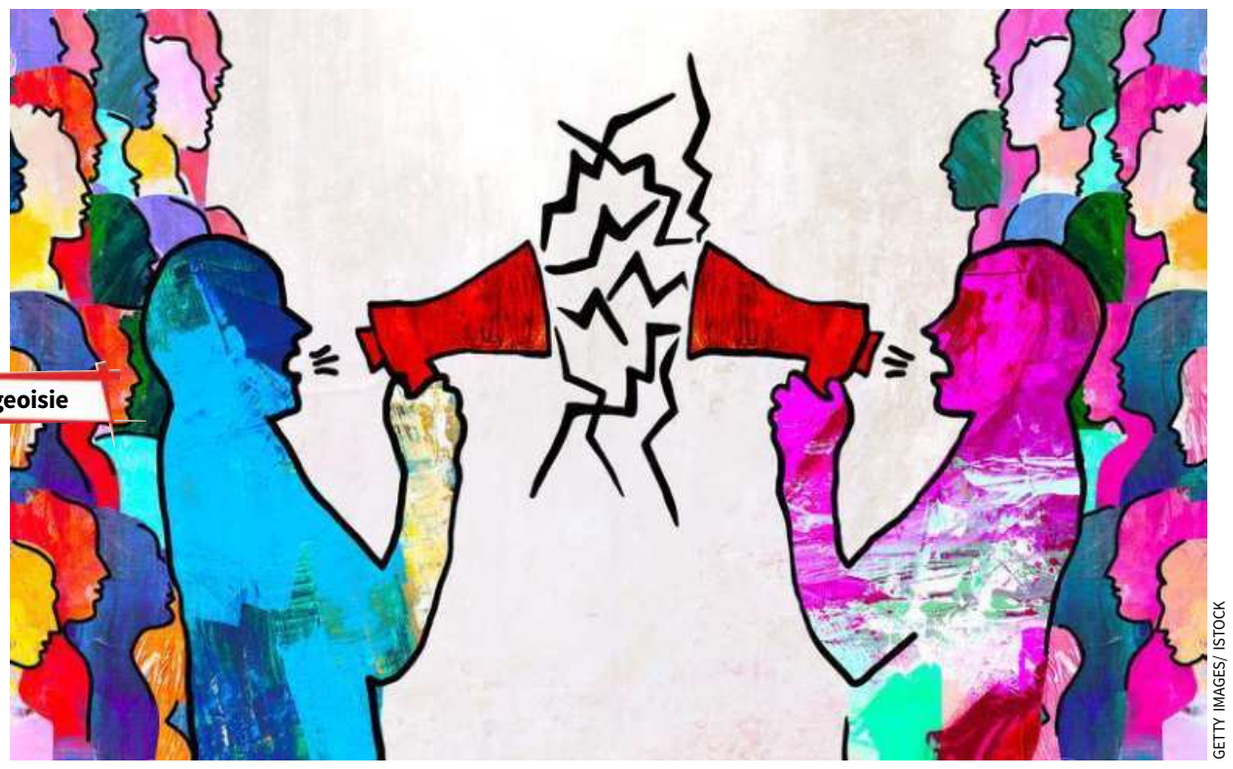


G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 39

CAN WE IMPORT CIVIC SENSE?

When there is a misplaced expectation of decency in a world filled with idiocy



GETTY IMAGES/ ISTOCK

Boorgeoisie
/ˌbʊəʒwɑːˈziː/
noun
Definition: The collective class of citizens who relentlessly complain about the lack of civic sense in Indian society while enthusiastically consuming, promoting, and profiting from the very culture of violence, rudeness, and chaos that makes civic sense impossible.
Related forms:
Boorgeois (*noun/ adjective*): A member of or relating to the boorgeoisie.
Boorgeoisification (*noun*): The process by which a society simultaneously dismantles and demands civic decency.

Dear reader, we are already in October! October! How did we get here? When did this happen? Were we informed? Why does this keep happening?

I have no idea. All I know is that once again, we find ourselves hurtling towards the end of yet another calendar year. The other day, I was speaking to a young software engineer. In the course of breaking the ice, we decided to swap life stories. "Okay, Sidin," he said. "Tell me about your work history. What kind of things have you done in life?"

"I have been working for exactly 25 years," I told him. "I started my first job way back in 2001."

He giggled. What happened, I asked him.

"Nothing, nothing. I just realised that you started working three years before I was born."

"Ha ha ha ha," I said, making a mental note to send this enterprising boy a box of *kaju katli*, laced with cyanide or arsenic or analogue *paneer* or some such, for Diwali.

"Sorry, sorry. No need to get upset, uncle," he said in jest.

Cyanide, arsenic *and* anologue *paneer*, I noted to myself. No point in taking any chances with such reprobates.

A few days later, I was recounting this chicanery to a friend, when he got quite upset. "Uncle, it seems!" he said. "You know what the problem is with kids these days, Sidin? They have zero civic sense. Absolutely none. Zero."

Readers, shall I make one confession? Just between you and me? I think Indians are making far too much of a fuss about civic sense. These days, you simply cannot browse the Internet, check social media, or even read a newspaper without someone, somewhere, complaining about our national lack of civic sense.

And you know what? I am fed up. Not because these complaints are unfounded. No. I dislike a driver propelling their car up the wrong side of the road as much as any of you. And I too cringe in embarrassment when I see fellow citizens chucking garbage out of their car windows. Or cutting the line at airports. Or defacing public property. Or pilfering things such as toiletries, blankets or bogeys from a train.

Make no mistake. These are all horrible things. And they must be condemned. But, my problem is with the constant moaning about "civic sense".

Let me explain. Look at the average superhit blockbuster film these days. The story usually involves a tremendously violent young man massacring people in wanton fashion, briefly pausing to sing one or two duets, before resuming the pillaging and murdering and beheading. But, of course, he is doing this for a good cause and therefore his rampages are to be forgiven. Not only that, we are then subject to endless YouTube Shorts and Instagram Reels valorising the noble violence of our protagonist.

Let us look at the average advertisement on TV these days. Perhaps, it will be a campaign for a new ugly, muscular Sport Utility Vehicle. This is my SUV, some ugly muscular fellow will say. I will use it to drive all over unspoilt nature. I will use it to play music loudly. I will speed all over this highway. Come, join me in driving an idiotic car like an idiot.

Or look at the average news programme on TV. A screeching anchor will encourage a smorgasbord of semi-sentient idiots to all scream at each other about some stupid trifle that has no material bearing on the welfare of a country that currently ranks 130th in the world when it comes to per-capita income. Often, a Mughal is involved in these absolute shenanigans. And of course, don't forget that the idiots all treat each other with animosity that is a hair's breadth short of homicide.

Readers, my point is this. If you subject the citizens of a nation to non-stop nonsense, morning to evening, in every conceivable setting, with no recourse to the merest experience of politeness, decency, or sociability, why in the world are you suddenly expecting civic sense? Where will it come from?

Maybe it can come from China. Can you import civic sense? Do you need a licence?

Anyway, I think we need a word to refer to this misplaced expectation of civic sense in a world where people are surrounded by unbearable idiots. And that word is: boorgeoisie.

Example sentence: "The boorgeoisie held an emergency meeting in the colony WhatsApp group to discuss the 'shocking decline in basic decency among today's youth', immediately after which three members got into a vicious argument about parking spaces that culminated in one uncle name-calling another uncle's wife."

Have you been complaining about civic sense recently? What is wrong with you? I will hit you with my SUV.



Sidin Vadukut *helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.*

GOREN BRIDGE

Junior shines

Neither vulnerable, South deals

Bob Jones

Today's deal is from a recent competition held in Denmark. East was a rising young Danish star, 16-year-old Nikolaj Hammelev. Declarer played low from dummy on the opening diamond lead and Hammelev took his king and returned a diamond to dummy's ace.

South, planning to take a heart finesse, led a low heart from dummy. The opponents were obviously in a 4-3 fit, but Hammelev knew the suit was splitting 3-3. Hammelev had a diamond trick and a sure trump trick to come, but how could they defeat this contract? His partner might have a club trick but that was it. Hammelev got creative. Hammelev played the queen of hearts! South took his ace but was now convinced that West held the other five trumps. South led a spade to the ace, cashed the king and ruffed a spade in hand. Hammelev discarded a diamond on the third spade instead of ruffing with the 10 of hearts, furthering the deception. "Knowing" that East had 10 cards in the minors, South led a club to the king and a club back to his jack. West took his queen and led a spade, Now Hammelev ruffed with the 10 of hearts and led a club. East ruffed for the setting trick and the contract was down one. Declarer needed a sedative.

NORTH
♠ A K 5 3
♡ K J 6
◇ A 2
♣ K 9 3 2

WEST
♠ Q 9 6 4 2
♡ 9 4 3
◇ J 9 3
♣ Q 7

EAST
♠ 10 8
♡ Q 10 7
◇ K 10 7 6 5
♣ 10 5 4

SOUTH
♠ J 7
♡ A 8 5 2
◇ Q 8 4
♣ A J 8 6

The bidding:

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♣	Pass	1♠	Pass
1NT	Pass	2◇*	Dbl
2♡	Pass	3♣	Pass
3NT	Pass	4♣**	Pass
4♡	All pass		

*Artificial game force
**Slam try

Opening lead: Three of ◇

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All about International Day of the Girl Child

Berty Ashley

1 Currently an advocate for the education of women and children, this girl began blogging anonymously for BBC Urdu about life under Taliban rule in Pakistan's Swat Valley when she was just 11 years old. After surviving an assassination attempt, she went on to become the youngest Nobel laureate at 17. Who is she?

2 This girl first learnt about climate change when she was eight years old and kept thinking about it, eventually suffering from depression. At 15, she started the "School Strike for Climate", which grew into a worldwide movement. Who is this young activist whose message is to "unite behind the science and to act on the science"?

3 Gitanjali Rao, a 15-year-old scientist and inventor from Colorado, developed a low-cost device to detect lead in drinking water, inspired by the Flint water crisis. She later created a technology-based service to detect early signs of prescription opioid addiction. In December 2020, she became the first recipient of a new "Kid of the Year" honour and appeared on the cover of which magazine?

4 Claudette Colvin was 15 years old when she was arrested in Montgomery, Alabama, on March 2, 1955. Nine months later, in the same city, Rosa Parks was arrested after doing something similar, and her arrest helped galvanise the civil rights movement. What had Claudette done to get arrested?



Mae Jemison was the first African-American woman to travel into space in 1992. (GETTY IMAGES)

5 Samantha Smith was 10 years old when she saw a 1982 issue of *TIME* magazine featuring Yuri Andropov, leader of the Soviet Union, on the cover. She asked her mother, 'Why doesn't someone write a letter asking whether he wants to have a war or not?' So she did, and Andropov invited her to Moscow, where she learnt about Soviet life and culture. The press dubbed her "America's youngest ____." What was the title?

6 Lydia Ko is an athlete from New Zealand who, on February 2, 2015, became the World No. 1 in her sport. At 17 years, nine months and nine days, she became the youngest player of either gender to reach No. 1. In which sport did she first tee off at the age of five?

7 When she was 12 years old, this girl dreamt of flying. She studied the anatomy of birds, investigated different materials and designed a plan for a flying machine, recording her ideas in what she called "Flyology". Though she never flew, she went on to become the world's first computer programmer. Who was she?

8 Cecilia Helena Payne was aged either 19 or 20 when she attended a lecture by Arthur Eddington, who had travelled to Africa to photograph a solar eclipse and test Einstein's General Theory of Relativity. Inspired by Eddington, she went on to study the stars and, in her doctoral thesis, established that stars are composed predominantly of which two elements?

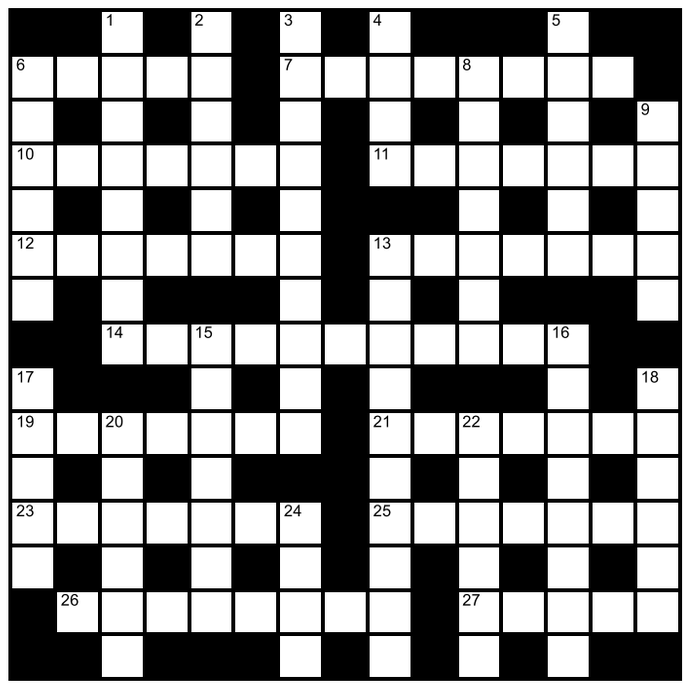
9 Mae Jemison was in kindergarten when she told her teacher she wanted to become a scientist. As a teenager, while watching the Apollo Moon missions, she was frustrated that there were no women astronauts. She eventually became the first African-American woman to travel into space, in 1992. In 1993, another dream came true when her favourite sci-fi TV show invited her to appear. Which show was it?

10 Nadia Comăneci was 14 when she scored the first perfect 10 in Olympic gymnastics history, for her uneven-bars routine at the 1976 Olympics. When her score appeared on the display board, it caused confusion. Instead of the perfect 10 she had earned, what score did the scoreboard display because it had not been programmed to show a 10.0?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

Answers
1. Malala Yousafzai
2. Greta Thunberg
3. *TIME*
4. Refused to give up her seat on a bus
5. America's youngest Ambassador
6. Golf
7. Ada Lovelace
8. Hydrogen and helium
9. *Star Trek: The Next Generation*
10. 1.00

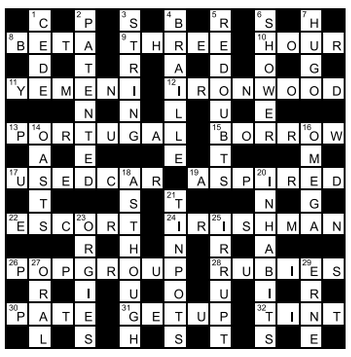
THE HINDU **SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 77** (Set by Arden)



Across
6 Brooded over means of transport (5)
7 It's plain — giving access to auditors isn't very bright (8)
10 An issue dogging the country is a curse (7)
11 Left her in a day, was cheated (7)
12 Herb's touring America, finds something to eat (7)
13 Fish drinking only pints — looks affected (7)
14 Red arrow — I score Greens (3-8)
19 Keeping animal in a haystack is part of habit (7)
21 Reduce setting dog after dog (7)
23 Nowadays guard becomes a guide (7)
25 King for single day (7)
26 Amusing to have a drink — this precedes the announcement (4,4)
27 Use dressing early to contain damage by burning (5)

Down
1 Acclaim for Jobs' creation across a country (8)
2 Some bypassed order, returned to port (6)
3 Snake oil seller will get on to eastern border (10)
4 Catcall from audience to follow all of them finally (4)
5 Mishit transformed these geological features (6)
6 Champagne and orange juice in the bush (6)
8 Music company entertains various plays (7)
9 Oddly, in India chaos prevails in state (5)
13 Least force applied on ship's bow (10)
15 Australian native to work with very big quantity (7)
16 Ill-gotton wealth, no middlemen involved in plant (8)
17 Run before shut down of a nuclear reactor (5)
18 Look at that cricketing shot! (6)
20 It flows always between poles (6)
22 Enjoy the dip (6)
24 Lost a club in shambles over disturbance (4)

SOLUTION NO. 76



Trees are more than just timber, they are a legacy

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Life is full of surprises. Mine, this time, is a green one. And it has a lot to do with the adage "One generation plants a tree, and another enjoys its shade". My maternal grandfather, a bishop, possessed a green thumb, as manifested through a majority of the trees in my garden.

Some of these, including the guava trees, the mulberry trees, the fig trees, and the mango tree, still exist and produce fruit in season.

One lemon variety was known for enormous fruit, one of which could be held in one hand at a time. It would hardly fit into the squeezer and had to be cut into small pieces. One lemon could churn out three or four glasses of yummy lemonade.

These trees, too, withered over the years, leaving us with sweet and sour memories. However, the roots of the righteous revive again even after staying dormant for centuries – a belief rooted in the Holy Bible. "The root of the righteous yieldeth fruit," says the Book of Proverbs 12:12. I know this is true as I have seen it unfold.

Having lain dormant for more than a decade, the roots of this lemon tree revived a couple of years ago.

While initially we dismissed it as a "useless weed", and would have removed it, the appearance of flowers and luscious fruit made us pause and think.

"It is a lemon tree, and it is not wild," said my gardener. "But we never planted one!" I interjected.

As it was very close to the spot where my grandfather had planted his, I realised that it was probably growing from the roots of the previous one.

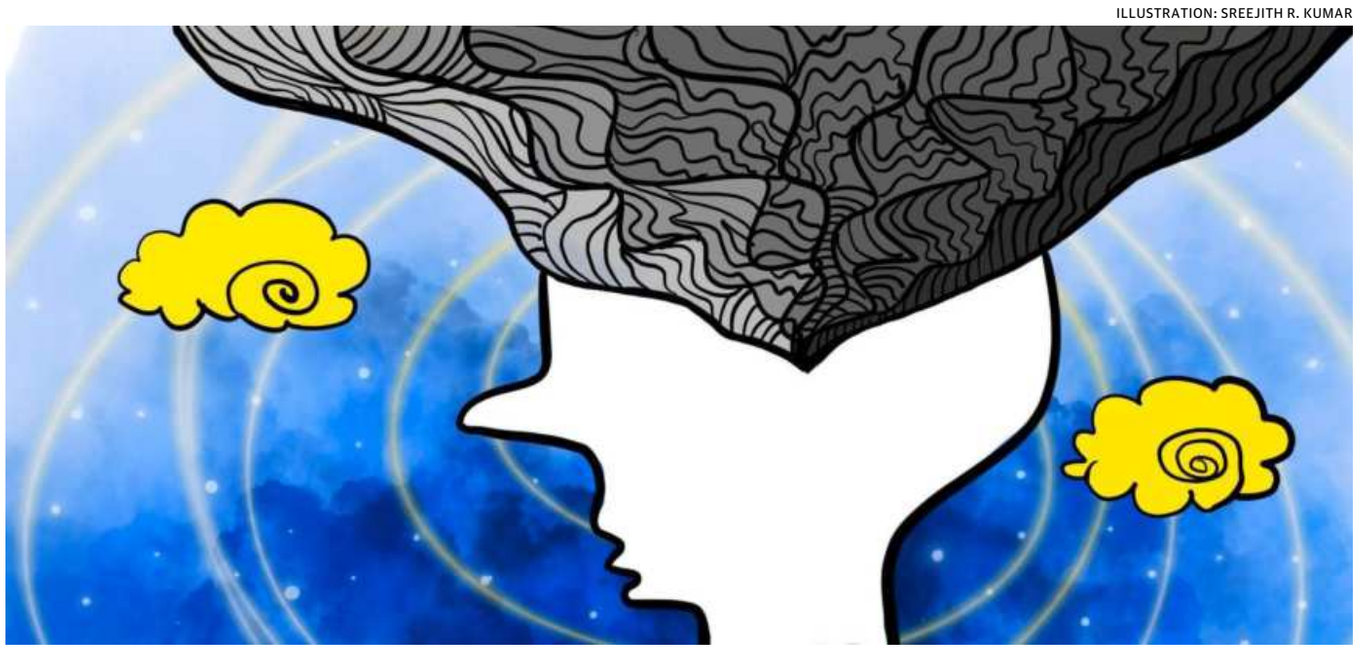
We held the axe and allowed it to grow. Now, it blesses us perennially with the most succulent lemons, similar to those we enjoyed in my grandfather's time.

Recently, my brother surprised us with something similar. A grapevine that our grandfather had planted in the house he lives in with his family, had sprouted again.

Though they tended it daily to the best of their abilities, the vine withered a few years ago. "It sprouted again this year, much to our joy and surprise," he said.

Trees, after all, are more than just timber. They are the living legacy of the righteous who plant them.

ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR



See the shades of grey

Having a mental illness does not strip one of abilities, worth, dignity; with the right support, compassion, and patience, it can be managed

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I went to one of the best colleges in the country; I work at a reputable firm, and I have authored books. That is the story that people like to hear. When I tell them I believe in mental health advocacy, they applaud me and nod respectfully. Who doesn't like a conventionally "successful" Gen-Z person with a conscience?

I live with mental illnesses. I have been on varying cocktails of psychiatric drugs for over eight years. I have had episodes where my actions have been reckless and risky, with consequences. This disclosure, in the blink of an eye, downgrades me from an "achiever" to an "aberration".

Over the past several years, on October 10, schools, colleges, and workplaces have proudly been celebrating World Mental Health Day with fanfare. You might have seen "It's okay not to be okay" and other phrases bandied around like hard-boiled candy over emails and posters. Don't get me wrong, we are lucky to be living in an era where people are warming to conversations on mental health and well-being, but we are terribly skittish when we hear about serious mental illness.

This year's theme is on lived experience, but the lived experience stories we hear are mostly limited to those who manage to defeat mental illness. The reality is that for many of us, recovery is not that straightforward; managing and living alongside what plagues us mentally is what healing looks like, realistically. I was diagnosed at a point of such deep distress that my ability to graduate was doubted. However, I graduated at the top of my batch and went on to do a demanding Master's degree. Most people think crossing such milestones is evidence that someone is thriving.

The truth is that there have been days when I barely survived. I did not run, walk or even trudge; I crawled.

People get frazzled when they hear about the unpleasant side of mental illness: depression that makes it hard to get out of bed, menacing hallucinations, crippling sadness that convinces one that suicide is the only solution, to name a few. In all fairness, you won't be able to fathom the gravity of this experience unless you have lived through it. But lived experience is not a prerequisite to being able to support someone else through theirs.

Lonely journey

While recovery, which is seldom linear, is a lonely journey, it is a collective fight. I was fortunate to have had the right kind of support. An army of people who did not necessarily understand me, but relentlessly and unflinchingly chose to stand by me anyway. Part of this was because I was vocal about my struggles. I got the help I needed in the form of reasonable accommodation at my college and workplaces. But speaking honestly is fraught with risks and is not possible for everyone because it comes at the cost of judgment and misunderstanding. I will not claim that my honesty has been devoid of judgment from others. Much to my chagrin, I have been misconstrued as an attention seeker, among several things. But I was still lucky. Lucky, because I had people who saw the duality of the pain I was in and the potential I had.

When I was diagnosed as a 19-year-old, I felt all alone and lost. I saw my first flicker of hope when I heard someone share their lived experience on social media. That stranger's story gave me the confidence to dream. I have not defeated my illness, but I am living alongside it, sometimes thriving, sometimes falling.

What I ask of you is to see the shades of grey that living with a mental illness encompasses. There will be good days, and there will be terrible ones. A good phase does not immunise one against a relapse, and a bad phase does not necessarily mean all progress made is lost. Recovery is a work in progress, and having a mental illness does not strip one of her abilities, worth, and dignity. While it makes life harder, with the right support, compassion and patience, mental illness can be managed.

Lived experience is beyond celebrating a clear victory over the illness. Every individual deserves to be seen, and every story deserves to be heard, including the messy ones with relapses and unfinished recoveries.

Healing is not one grand triumph; small wins are worthy of being cherished too. Only when we hear the full spectrum of what it means to live with mental illness can we begin to offer meaningful support.

The tyranny of 'If only'

With hindsight, the road not taken looks like the road that should have been taken

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While speaking at a meeting in Kochi recently, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby lamented that the INDIA bloc had failed to keep the then Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and the Janata Dal(U) within its fold. Had they succeeded, he suggested, the political future of India might have been very different. Perhaps he is right. Perhaps he is not.

But his remark points to a fascinating aspect of human nature. It is captured in two simple words: "If only..." Those words echo through politics, history, business, and our personal lives. They are the vocabulary of hindsight. "If only Nitish Kumar had remained with the INDIA bloc..." "If only the Pinarayi Vijayan government had adhered more closely to the simplicity and austerity traditionally associated with communist ideals, public disillusionment might not have grown so deep..."

After every event comes a flood of explanations. Once the outcome is known, alternative paths suddenly appear obvious. The road not taken begins to look like the road that should have been taken. History is full of such reflections. After the outbreak of the First World War, historians spent generations asking: "If only European powers had exercised greater restraint." Millions of lives might have been saved. After the rise of Adolf Hitler and the horrors of the Second World War came another round of hindsight: "If only the Treaty of Versailles had not humiliated Germany." "If only Britain and France had confronted Hitler earlier."



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Today, those conclusions seem self-evident. Yet they were anything but obvious to those living through those events. The *Titanic* disaster generated similar wisdom after the fact. "If only the ship had slowed down." "If only the iceberg warnings had been taken more seriously." "If only there had been sufficient lifeboats." Every one of these observations is correct. Yet not one of them could alter a single fact after the tragedy had occurred.

Indian history offers many such examples. Following the Partition of 1947, generations have debated whether the subcontinent's fate could have been different. "If only political leaders had found another compromise." After the Emergency of 1975 came another series of questions. "If only democratic institutions had resisted more firmly." The assassination of Rajiv Gandhi triggered endless post-mortems. "If only security arrangements had been different."

Wiser after the event

History invariably makes us wiser. The problem is that it tends to do so after the event. Business history offers equally powerful lessons. Today, management experts routinely say: "If only Kodak had embraced digital photography earlier." "If only Nokia had recognised the smartphone revolution in time." Yet those decisions were made in a world where the future was uncertain, not obvious.

No amount of regret can change the past. No amount of anxiety can change the future. No amount of hindsight can alter history

The same pattern repeats in our personal lives. "If only I had accepted that opportunity." "If only I had devoted more attention to my health." "If only I had spent more time with my parents." "If only I had spoken more kindly." Such reflections are not entirely useless. They can teach valuable lessons. But they become dangerous when they trap us in regret rather than inspire growth.

For there is a fundamental truth about life. No amount of regret can change the past. No amount of anxiety can change the future. Yet, any amount of gratitude can change the present. This is where real wisdom begins.

Nelson Mandela emerged from 27 years of imprisonment without becoming a prisoner of bitterness. Helen Keller, despite losing both sight and hearing, chose gratitude over self-pity. Their greatness did not lie in escaping adversity but in refusing to be defined by it. However, there is another irony hidden within the politics of "if only".

Every political movement believes that history's lessons apply to others. Every generation assumes it is wiser than the previous one. Every leadership is convinced that its setbacks are temporary and that the public simply failed to understand its intentions.

The German philosopher Hegel made a famous observation: "The only thing we learn from history is that we learn nothing from history." Few statements describe politics more accurately. After every defeat come explanations. After every crisis come analyses. After every disaster come experts telling us what should have been done. And after every explanation comes another opportunity to repeat the same mistakes. That is why the phrase "If only..." never disappears from human discourse.

Illuminate mistakes

Yet the purpose of history is not to provide material for endless regret. History exists to illuminate mistakes before they are repeated, not merely to explain them after they occur. The past cannot be rewritten. The future cannot be guaranteed. But the present can be transformed by learning from the past and acting wisely in the moment available to us. That is the difference between wisdom and hindsight. Otherwise, today's "if only" becomes tomorrow's history, and tomorrow's history becomes another "if only" for the next generation. As someone wisely observed: No amount of regret can change the past. No amount of anxiety can change the future. But any amount of gratitude can change the present. To which one may add: No amount of hindsight can alter history. But a willingness to learn from history can alter the future. For history does not really repeat itself. Human beings, refusing to learn from history, repeat it for history.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The renewed interest in non-violent protest among youngsters is encouraging. ('The young and the *satyagraha*'; Oct. 4) However, dissent must extend beyond social media and occasional demonstrations. Educational institutions should introduce students to constitutional rights, peaceful negotiation and civic responsibility.
Abbharna Barathi

Rohit Kumar's article rightly highlights the continuing relevance of Gandhi's ideals among today's youth. That the Jantar Mantar protesters returned in greater numbers after the violence of July 20, and stayed until their demand was met, shows the courage and persistence that *satyagraha* demands.
P.A. Chary

Different paths, one goal

In the journey towards true equality, Gandhi and Ambedkar took different paths of reforms, but the ultimate destination for both was the emancipation of people of India. ('Bringing Ambedkar and Gandhi together'; Oct. 4) Ramachandra Guha rests his arguments with facts and figures on the legacies of Gandhi and Ambedkar.
Ayyasseri Raveendranath

Reality through art

Concrete jungles are mushrooming across the length and breadth of the country in the name of development with scant regard for biodiversity or the climate. ('Green Humour'; Oct. 4) Distress migration, commercialisation of commons, disappearing grasslands, soil erosion, declining groundwater tables, polluted air and degraded landscapes are stark realities the country is grappling with.
Kosaraju Chandramouli

Social crusader

Most of us would shy away from even entering slums, leave alone interacting with slum dwellers or lending a ear to their grievances. But, committed social workers like Sujata Sawant continue to render yeoman service and contribute to the upliftment of the downtrodden. May her tribe increase.
C.V. Aravind

Sustained partnerships

Chanakya International's exhibitions demonstrate how traditional craftsmanship can engage with contemporary artistic ideas. ('Goddesses in the everyday'; Oct. 4) India's artisan communities need more than ceremonial recognition; they require fair remuneration, training and dependable markets. Museums and design institutions should build sustained partnerships with craftspeople.
P.S. Harishmitha

Social record

Documentary photography offers an important record of ordinary lives amid conflict and social change. ('Seamus Murphy's poetic realism'; Oct. 4) Such visual documentation deserves greater recognition in India's cultural institutions. Public galleries and educational establishments could organise accessible exhibitions accompanied by discussions on the people and places depicted.
M. Barathi

MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Queues, crowds, and the fear of missing out
What forces people to break decorum on and off the road
Sindhuja Ramasubramanian

How social media distorts reality
The consequences of spending more time behind screens than in real interactions
Sanskriti Pokhriyal

The school status syndrome
The craze for snazzy private institutions
Pranesh Kumar

Taking wing for the first time
Flying is routine now, but the first flight is different
Krishna Kumar R.

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(Clockwise from right) Zandra Rhodes with American fashion editor Diana Vreeland at the 1982 Met Gala; outfits from Rhodes' archive; the fashion designer; a beaded Manhattan dress from the AW 1985 'India Revisited' collection; Annie Mammen; and Tambour x Zandra. (ROBYN BEECHE, JOHAN SATHYA DAS, AND COURTESY ZANDRA RHODES FOUNDATION)



ZANDRA RHODES
INDIA ON HER MIND

Known for dressing icons such as Freddie Mercury and living life in technicolour, the British design legend has a very good reason to visit Chennai

Rosella Stephen
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Zandra Rhodes has 100 pages of photos on Getty Images, each photo a lesson in chromatic flamboyance. It's not just the signature hot pink hair and electric blue eyeshadow but the outsized rings and brooches, the kaleidoscopic prints and her appetite for life. When we get on a video call, she talks about her upcoming trip to India and Chennai in particular with the giddy anticipation of a first-time visitor.

One would never guess she was here in March for a talk at Bangalore International Centre (BIC), and a few months before that, for a textile and print-making workshop in Jaipur. In cheery yellow, with rings the size of quail eggs on her fingers and her hand-drawn prints as backdrop, Rhodes is curious and recalls details with startling precision. At 86, having stared down cancer, she has been known to work from 8 a.m. to 6 p.m. and is still making, exhibiting and collaborating – the last being the reason why she is heading to Chennai.

Pashmina and poems

Rhodes has partnered with Tambour's Annie Titus Mammen, whose embroidery expertise has been sought by leading European luxury houses, and with whom she has worked since 1985. Together they are presenting a limited edition of finely crafted Pashmina shawls, featuring five original Zandra Rhodes designs and translated across 35 colourways.

I ask her about the first thing she will do when she arrives. Have a cup of Indian masala *chai*, she chuckles. But work will continue nonstop. She has an exhibition opening at De Montfort University in Leicester, where she has donated designs made for companies including Marks & Spencer, IKEA and Topshop so that students can study it. Her Zandra Rhodes Foundation is working through an archive of more than 8,000 garments, deciding where they should ultimately live. "I'm basically a textile designer who then kept finding jobs," she says, recalling her early years.

She has often talked about being a "print designer who ended up making exotic caftans and shawls" initially, before her name became inseparable from exuberant prints, handwork, colour and sculptural clothes. Her Knitted Circle yellow felt coat from her first collection in 1969 remains her most beloved creation and an example of how her print determined the shape of her garments. Covered in beading, the coat became one of the pieces that carried her work across America and into American *Vogue*. This insistence on textiles as design was unusual at the time. "As I'm now quite old," she says with a laugh, "I suppose you could say I was one of the first to point out how important textiles are."

Lessons in saris

When Rhodes first came to India in 1981, she encountered something that she felt Britain was in danger of losing: the continued presence of handicrafts and handlooms. She was introduced to India not simply as an aesthetic but as a network of people and processes by designer and scenographer Rajeev Sethi, for the Festival of India. She tells me how the sari, in particular, "an art form in itself", changed something for her. She later created a sari show that was chosen to represent India in Japan for the Festival of India there.

For Rhodes, the shawl has always offered a particular kind of theatre. "Shawls can give mystery," she says. "You can get wonderful effects with them." The new shawls being developed for India use some of her most recognisable motifs: ladies' heads with elaborate hair and eyelashes, bows, flowers and words. There are peacock feathers, some drawn and some picked out with small amounts of beading. One design recalls A Field of Poems, her print of flowers and writing. The motifs come, as so much of her work does "from things in my sketchbooks that I've been drawing through the years", she says.









Gen Z and Rhodes

We get talking about young designers and Rhodes says she is honoured to be still recognised for Freddie Mercury's pleated cape that she designed. Or Princess Anne's engagement dress, with machine embroidery and seashells. Or Princess Diana's delicate pink dress worn when she announced her pregnancy in Japan. Rhodes' employees are in their early 20s and when they find her old pieces online, they arrive to work excited. "The younger generation, I think, are much more curious," she says.

Her archival designs are not necessarily there to be preserved exactly as they were. Having watched the industry pass through punk, elaborate embroidery, beaded dresses, the many cycles of fast fashion, and now the return of vintage and re-wearing clothes, she knows her archives are priceless both to design students and collectors. "We should all consider throwing away less and working out how to wear things differently so that they keep a long life," she says.

Friendships and giving back

Her own history in India is inseparable from the people who made that handwork possible. Over the years, Mammen has become an important collaborator and friend. Now, she wants to return the favour, Rhodes says. "I want to give back to India what they've given to me because it's widened the whole of my life." That impulse is behind conversations she is having with museums in India, including MAP in Bangalore, about the heritage she and Sethi helped put together. In London, meanwhile, the Zandra Rhodes Foundation is working out the future of her enormous archive. The Victoria and Albert Museum has been giving them a wish list. The Metropolitan Museum in New York is another possibility.

Meanwhile, the pink hair

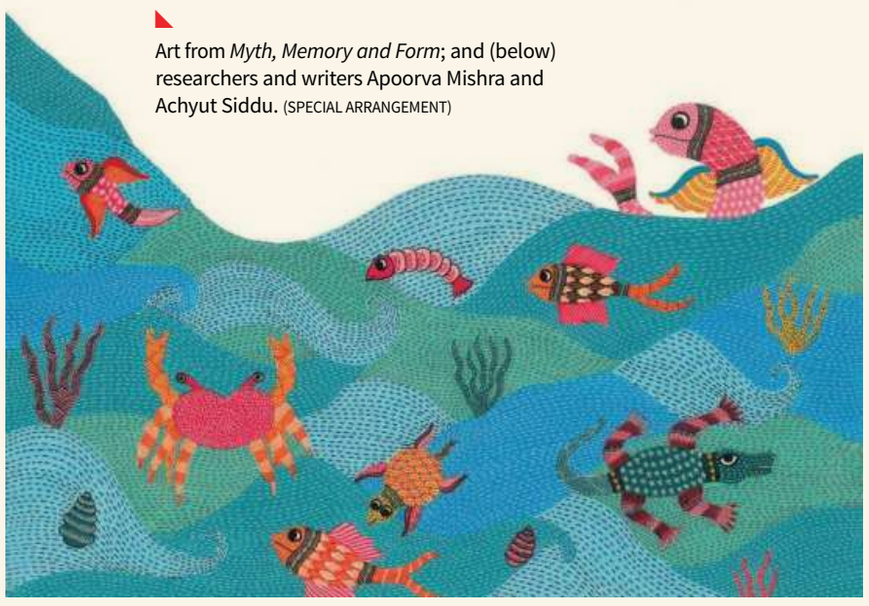
Rhodes says her pink hair and dramatic makeup was not a carefully constructed branding exercise. "It gradually grew into that," she reveals with a smile. She first dyed her hair in 1973, liked how it felt and the colour became part of her visual identity – helped, perhaps, by Diana Vreeland's famous observation that pink is "the navy blue of India". Which brings us to Jaipur, where she has purchased jewellery for decades. And her most recent Indian adventure, which took her to Hampi for 10 days, sketching among the rocks. Now Chennai beckons and she is busy planning her wardrobe for it. "When I'm in India, I have to try extra hard to make sure I can compete with all the beauty that's going on," she insists. The line is pure Rhodes: playful, self-aware and completely sincere. And we love her for it.

An Evening with Zandra Rhodes and Tambour at Evoluzione, Chennai, is on October 13. The collection is priced from ₹21,600.

Behind Gond's sacred stories

Myth, Memory and Form asks what is gained, and lost, when indigenous knowledge is transformed into art

Ritika Kochhar



Art from *Myth, Memory and Form*; and (below) researchers and writers Apoorva Mishra and Achyut Siddu. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Stretched accordion style across a corner of Varija Art Gallery in DakshinaChitra Museum is a 7.5-metre book titled *The Pardhaan Continuum*. This monumental illustrated story charts the rich history of the Pardhaan Gonds, a sub-community of the Gond tribes, one of the oldest indigenous Dravidian groups in India. It captures the myth of their sacred origin, traditional rituals and deities, anchoring itself around the stories of Bada Dev, their supreme creator.

The ongoing exhibition is curated and designed by architects, researchers and writers Apoorva Mishra and Achyut Siddu. They are also the co-founders of Loksutr, a Madhya Pradesh-based design research practice that translates oral traditions and classical texts into illustrated manuscripts, books, and art. For *Myth, Memory and Form*, National Award-winning Gond artists such as Kailash Pradhaan and Ajay Marko, alongside Pattachitra artist Prahallad Moharana, recorded and transformed the community's oral narratives into paintings. "We've worked closely with Pardhaans [historically, they have served as the community's priests, hereditary bards and genealogists] from Patangarh village in Madhya Pradesh's Dindori district for over three years," says Siddu. "Loksutr's purpose isn't livelihood generation, but to create the conditions for knowledge that's currently inaccessible, hard to parse, or overlooked to find real expression and reach people."

Retelling ancient tales

On the museum's walls hang 40 paintings, including a 10ft x 20ft canvas depicting the origin story of the River Narmada in a single, continuous scene. Most people know the 8th century CE *Skanda Purana* version, which describes Shiva sitting in such intense meditation that his sweat trickles down and morphs into a dancing woman named Narmada (*narma* means humour and *da* giver), later transforming into the sacred river.

However, the story told by Gangaram Uikey, a Pardhaan Gond from Patangarh, is different. In his version, Shiva and Parvati seek a lifeless place where the former can share the tale of immortality. They find a bamboo forest within the Satpura mountains, but Parvati falls asleep during the narration. Unaware, Shiva continues speaking, and the power of the tale animates two parrot eggs, granting them immortality. Furious at these unwanted witnesses, Shiva chases away the birds. Three drops of his sweat fall to the earth to form the rivers Narmada, Johila, and the Behtarni stream.

"Loksutr's work responds to the triple challenges faced by India's indigenous knowledge, which still lives in oral, performative and transient forms, or sits in specialist archives that prevent the wider public from interacting with it," Siddu shared at the inaugural lecture at Alliance Française of Madras. "When you strip a myth down to its essence – its archetypes, emotional resonance, and cultural symbols – it ceases to be just an old story and becomes a foundational blueprint for how we shape both the physical and digital worlds."



Of consent and control

"It is vital for us to understand Loksutr's process of transforming an archive into art," says Anitha Pottamkulam, director (culture) at DakshinaChitra. "A lot of well-meaning initiatives fail due to a lack of rigorous ethics. Take the recent news report about the apex body [Idu Mishmi Cultural and Literary Society] representing the indigenous Idu Mishmi community in Arunachal Pradesh's Dibang Valley. They officially blacklisted four researchers for violating localised ethical standards."

The researchers entered indigenous community lands before receiving consent from the community's Research and Ethics Review Board, and conducted "extraction-based" academic research, taking data and biological samples without meaningful, long-term participation or shared benefits for the locals. "What's happened with the Idu Mishmi community is a warning about research and knowledge extraction that proceeds without the community's consent and control," Pottamkulam says.

At a time when most Gond artists struggle to articulate the thinking behind their art, Loksutr's research serves as a poignant reminder: selling indigenous art without recording the traditional knowledge behind it creates a product as hollow as the frantic flight of those two parrot hatchlings trying to escape Shiva's wrath.

But, equally, it raises urgent questions. What happens when an oral story ends up as an image on someone's phone? Does the story cease to be an event you experience and become an object you consume? Does writing one version of a story negate all other versions that live on in the memory? In the age of decolonisation and digitalisation, the exhibition sends the audience home with more questions to wrestle with.

Myth, Memory and Form *is on till December 6 at DakshinaChitra.*

The writer is an expert on South Asian art and culture.